ground towards Cortenuova, farther to the east, and then surrounded them. On November 27, 1237, the emperor's army killed or took prisoner over half of the Milanese soldiers and seized almost all of their horses, wagons, and supplies.

The remainder fled; and Frederick, bolstered by his victory, demanded the unconditional surrender of the city. Milan refused. "We fear your cruelty," they wrote back, in response, "which we know by experience; we had rather die under our shields by sword, spear, or dart, than by treachery, starvation, and fire." Instead, they dug themselves in for the winter; and their resistance encouraged the other Lombard cities to rejoin the battle.[12]

It had become increasingly clear to Gregory IX that Frederick's designs on Italy would, eventually, reach down to Rome itself. The temporary truce between the two men was fragile; cooperation against heretics would last only so long, as a common bond. Gregory IX's attempts to negotiate peace between emperor and Lombards were rejected. When, early in 1239, Frederick landed troops on the shores of the island of Sardinia, which the pope claimed as his own territory, Gregory IX rose up in wrath and condemned the emperor's ambitions: "The hatred which sprung up between the pope and the emperor, like an old wound, produced foul matter," records the English chronicler Matthew Paris. In the Lenten season, Gregory IX pronounced Frederick II not only excommunicated but deposed.[13]